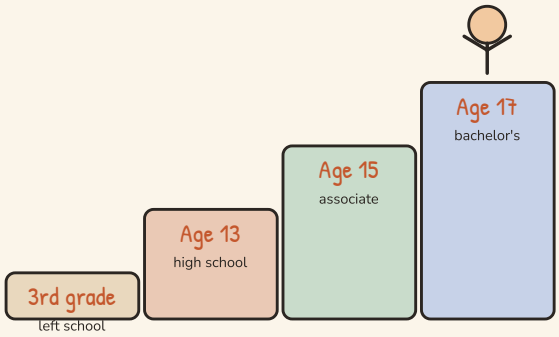


ask before you commit

The Early College Questions Checklist

What to ask a college, how to start small, and what I learned finishing an associate degree at 15 and a bachelor's at 17.

PRINTABLE PDF · 7 PAGES

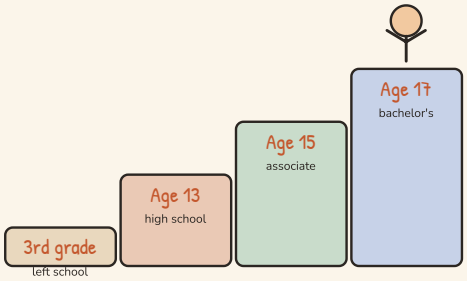
by Fabian Capre

my route

How I did it

One person's path, not a rule. Colleges and policies change, so use this to ask better questions.

I left in-person school in 3rd grade, finished high school through FLVS Flex in 2021 at 13, then took the placement test (the PERT, at the time), and enrolled in Palm Beach State College. It wasn't hard to get in, because on paper I had satisfied what was required. I earned my associate degree in political science in 2023, at 15, taking most of my classes online while still joining things on campus. Then I transferred to Florida Atlantic University and earned my bachelor's in 2025, at 17.



What it was like

Starting college on a campus at 13 wasn't bad. Most students were college freshmen, so I didn't stand out. The bigger adjustment came later: taking in-person classes at the university was my first time in a classroom in years, and it took getting used to.

What worked

- Starting with online classes to build confidence
- Joining things on campus, not just classes
- Finding friends who shared my interests
- Being upfront with instructors when I needed something

What was hard

- The shock when people learned my age
- Moving from online to in-person classes
- Managing my time on my own

Rules about age, placement tests, credits and enrollment vary by college and state and change over time. Always check with the college directly.

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part 1

Is your child ready for college classes?

Answer together. This isn't a test; it's a conversation starter.

1 Does the learner want to try college classes, not just agree because you do?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

2 Are they comfortable asking adults questions and asking for help?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

3 Can they manage a schedule, deadlines and reading on their own, with some support?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

4 Do they understand what they learn, not only finish it?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

5 Are they okay being among older students?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

6 Is there a parent or trusted adult they can talk to when something feels off?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

7 Can they slow down or withdraw without feeling like they failed?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

8 Do you have a plan for friends and activities outside class?
◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

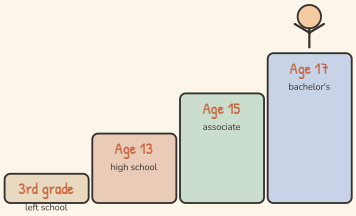
From my experience

The classes weren't the hardest part. It was being young among older students and managing my own time. Being able to say "this is hard" to my parents, without it feeling like failing, mattered most.

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part 2

Questions to ask the college



Write the answer, the date, and who answered. Ask for important answers in writing.

Question	Answer	Date / who
What are the age and grade requirements? Any exceptions?		
Which tests, transcripts or interviews are needed?		
What does it cost? Are there programs that help?		
Which credits transfer, and where? (Get it in writing.)		
In person, online, or both?		
Who is our contact? Is there an advisor?		
What role do parents have for a minor?		
How does this affect financial aid and later admissions?		
What is the withdrawal policy if it isn't working?		

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part 3

Start small



A plan for the first term.

1. **Take one or two classes.** Think of it as a test of fit.
2. **Pick the format on purpose.** Online first, or in person first? Mine was online first.
3. **Read each syllabus on day one,** and put every deadline on a calendar.
4. **Introduce yourself to instructors,** and decide together how and whether to share your age.
5. **Find one club or group.** It made the campus feel like mine.
6. **Check in every month** and decide together: add more, stay the same, or pause.

What worked for me

Joining clubs and organizations on campus, and making friends where we shared interests. At the university, I also made friends with a lot of high schoolers because the campus had a high school on it.

What I'd watch for

Overloading the first term. Pushing past stress instead of saying something. And skipping the social side because the classes feel like enough.

Money

I received a few scholarships, including ones specific to my college and one from an honors society. Ask each college about scholarships early, including the ones tied to that school or to clubs and honors programs.

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keep track

Your college tracker

One row per college or program you're exploring.

College / program	Age & entry rules	Format	Credits transfer?	Cost / aid	Contact	Notes

Our decision, and the date we'll review it

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before you go

Records and next steps



Keep these safe

- [ ] High school diploma or completion records
- [ ] Official transcripts from every school or program
- [ ] A course list with dates and descriptions
- [ ] Test results, if any
- [ ] Emails and forms from the college
- [ ] An activity log (clubs, volunteering, internships)

From my experience

In my second-to-last semester I took part in a legislative internship program through the university. I spent the legislative session in Tallahassee, working with a state representative and living on my own for the first time. It was a new step, and my age didn't get in the way. Early college opened doors I didn't know to look for.

About the author

Fabian Capre left in-person school in 3rd grade and was homeschooled from then on. He completed high school through FLVS Flex in 2021 at 13, earned his associate degree in political science from Palm Beach State College in 2023 at 15, and his bachelor's degree in political science from Florida Atlantic University in 2025 at 17. He is now working on a master's degree.

He is not a licensed teacher, counselor or lawyer. He shares what worked for him, what was hard, and what he would do differently.

General information from one person's experience. Not educational, psychological, medical or legal advice. Rules and options vary by state, district and college; check the official sources where you live.

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